



1



2

treasury, and former harem offers a fascinating glimpse into imperial life. The palace terraces also provide stunning views of the Bosphorus and the Golden Horn.

A short walk away, and you straddle civilisations at the Hippodrome that offers a glimpse into the Byzantine world. Once the social and political centre of Constantinople, it hosted chariot races and public ceremonies attended by tens of thousands. Today, only fragments remain, yet standing beside the ancient Egyptian Obelisk and the Serpent Column, it is easy to imagine the crowds that once filled the arena.

However, what makes Istanbul truly special, is not simply its monuments but the way different cultures coexist within the city.

For centuries, Turkish, Greek, Arab, Jewish, and countless other communities have contributed to its development.

Food plays a central role in this melting pot of cultural experience. Every morning begins with a traditional Turkish breakfast, or *kahvaltı*. Tables overflow with cheeses, olives, fresh bread, honey, jams, vegetables, and eggs. Equally memorable is the city's obsession with tea and coffee. Tiny tulip-shaped glasses of strong black tea—*Çay* (pronounced *chai*) appear everywhere accompanying every conversation.

But it is Turkish coffee that is the cultural export to the world. Turkey exported 8,652 tonnes of coffee to 146 countries in 2024, generating \$57.4 million in revenue. Recognised as a part of UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage,



3